

KF41 Meeting Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

This month we will learn **Alternate Nostril Breathing**. If you want to know more about this technique, you can search the web for *alternate nostril breathing*. Here are some of the benefits of this breathing method:

- Enhances the connection between your mind and your body
- Revitalizes a tired mind and relaxes you for sleep
- Improves overall brain function
- Balances your autonomic nervous system
- Cleanses your energetic pathways
- Reduces anxiety and helps you manage your emotions

Alternate Nostril Breathing

Let’s begin. Assume a meditation posture and breathe naturally for thirty seconds. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Now, using your right hand, press your thumb against your right nostril, closing it off as you inhale. *(Pause)* On the exhale, release your thumb and press your index or middle finger against your left nostril, closing it off. *(Pause)* Practice this simple pattern a few times. Explore how you feel when you close off a nostril. If your sinuses are not clear, breath through your mouth. *(Pause for 20 seconds)*

How did it feel to close off a nostril? Let’s continue to learn and explore the complete finger pattern. Use the hand and the finger that feel most comfortable for you. Press on one nostril with the thumb as you inhale. *(Pause)* Then release the thumb and press on the other nostril with the finger as you exhale. *(Pause)* Hold the finger in place while you inhale. *(Pause)* On the exhale, release the finger and press with the thumb. *(Pause)* Thumb press, inhale. Finger press, exhale. Hold finger, inhale. Thumb press, exhale. Hold thumb, inhale. *(Pause)* Simply switch nostrils on the exhale. Practice for two minutes at your own pace. *(Pause for 2 minutes, announcing when 1 minute has passed)*

Pause. Notice how you feel. *(Pause)* Now return to the meeting.

It's beneficial to begin your meditation time with a few minutes of **Alternate Nostril Breathing**, but this breathing technique can also be used to calm your mind before sleep or to clear your mind for work and creativity. Always keep in mind that KF introduces a variety of tools and methods that you might try. Work with what works for you.

Our hymn is *O Love That Will Not Let Me Go*.

O Cross that lifts up my head,
I dare not ask to fly from Thee.
I lay in dust life's glory dead,
And from the ground there blossoms red
Life that shall endless be.¹

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

This month we will begin to explore the amazing potential of KF Confession 10:

We honor our limitations and seek lives of gratitude.

Last week, we learned that our adventures help us discover and recover our True Self. Trying new things gives us opportunities to learn how to manage change, which is a natural component of life. Life is flowing on, and when we refuse to adventure, we dissipate this precious resource and squander its powerful flow only to defend the wasteland of our pride and maintain a miserable fortress of illusion. Locked up in that fortress, we cannot stretch our ability to manage the flow of life and, therefore, will feel intense anxiety whenever we perceive a threat, encounter real limitations, or are invited to change. Our anxious minds invent stories of *what if* and *if only*.² We fear missing out and we fear getting stuck, but we create a fortress that will ensure both of those results!

Limitations threaten our pride system. Hurt pride then triggers our habitual patterns of self-hate, and self-hate lashes us into ways of believing and behaving that we later regret. The beliefs and behaviors that stem from our self-hate do not honor God or His purposes; they simply support the Idol's survival. Gratitude goes out the window, and we become disconnected from ourselves, from our community, and from God. Your Idol desperately wants you to stop growing, but with your KF tools, you can manage your self-hate and choose training that will liberate the potential of your True Self. Ask God. Work toward simplicity. Adventure into new territory, and then develop priorities.

When your life is simpler and you are less motivated by the frenzy of the Idol's compulsive needs, you have more resources available for risking adventure. You can then set real priorities that keep your investment in your True Self on track and protect all that you have gained by your efforts. Priorities reveal what you actually value. For example, do you value making a generous impression on Christmas morning, or do you value freedom from debt? Would you spend money on a new wardrobe or an exciting vacation rather than invest in effective healthcare? Are your values in conflict with your limitations? Debt and poor health are limitations that restrict your possibilities. They are most often self-imposed and are a kind of

slavery. You can't go anywhere when your foot is nailed to the ground. So, the question really is: *Will you restrict your future possibilities for a little euphoria today, or will you choose to honor today's limitations so that you can invest in tomorrow's possibilities?* What are your choices telling you about your priorities?

Healthy priorities honor your limitations and become part of your default thinking; they simplify the process of making decisions. Be *makrothumos* with yourself as you work on KF Confession 10. You live in a society that encourages you to mindlessly run around dumping your resources. This affluent culture wants you to believe that you can do it all and deserve to do it all—right now. It doesn't want you to be content with your design and what you are doing, or with what you have and where you are today. Could it be that our society is neurotic? It's a jungle out there, and you will have to develop priorities in order to confidently and firmly take care of your business.

When we are tempted to make choices based on “as soon as possible”, we can consider the KF version of the acronym ASAP—Ask, Simplify, Adventure, Prioritize. In our misorientation, we ignore our limitations and default to destructive patterns of thought and behavior; and in a frantic attempt to escape our anxiety, we compulsively try to make something happen as soon as possible. Now, we are learning to ask, simplify, adventure, and then develop our priorities.

In chapter 5 of *Neurosis and Human Growth*, Dr. Horney writes:

The neurotic is a frustrated being—his drives, conflicts, and alienation from self all prevent him from realizing his potential. He feels frustrated because he claims unlimited ability to do it all.³

When we are neurotic, it is very difficult to identify and defend priorities that will lead us to our oriented development and potential. Priorities are exactly like running a financial budget or counting calories. They are a means of living within the limitations of being a human creature. There is only so much money, ability, time, and health to go around, and you must decide how you will spend those resources. Through asking God, simplifying your life, and adventuring against the Idol's imposed and imaginary limitations, you discover your real limitations and can then develop your real priorities.

You are a growing, changing, and unique creature, so your priorities need to be clear, flexible, and tailor-made. Clear priorities will help you direct your life, and flexible priorities can be adjusted to changing circumstances. What do you really want? Your everyday decisions will reveal the answer. Train hard to establish healthy priorities so that you can fight easy when difficult decisions must be made. You are becoming confident about who you are and what God would have you do. Your true life is emerging, and you are finally willing to fight for it.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Lord, show me Your priorities as You help me discover mine. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?”)

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

Let's look at the end of a well-known passage in chapter 6 of the Gospel of Matthew. Jesus has been talking to the crowd about serving two masters. He says that you just can't do it. You will love one and hate the other. You cannot serve two masters. That is a limitation.

Who are the masters that Jesus is talking about in this passage? One is God, and the other is mammon. We think of mammon as wealth or money, but mammon is really more about an attitude. Mammon was thought to be the god of avarice or greed, so Jesus is teaching us that greed can rule over us like a god. Our compulsive needs create a kind of greed, and that greed drives us to steal from others in order to allay our anxiety and support our pride. Our unhealthy fear of imagined limitations and deprivation compels us to make up virtue stories about why it is acceptable to snatch and steal from others and avoid circulating with them. Accomplished greed guarantees the Idol's survival and temporarily pacifies our basic anxiety. When greed is accomplished, our Idol can enjoy a moment of self-satisfied pride.

Jesus wants us to give up our greed. He reminds us of what in reality we need today: food, drink, and clothing. By identifying our real needs, Jesus invalidates our virtue stories—those stories that we tell ourselves and others to justify our greed. He exposes the egocentricity lurking behind our choice to fight for, defend, and snatch at things and activities that are not real needs and only serve to maintain our pride. When we simplify our lives and trust God for what we need, we learn to recognize the many gifts of support that are already ours. We learn to be grateful rather than greedy. When we are living in gratitude, everything becomes a gift. Gratitude is the opposite of greed.

In the passage for this lesson, Jesus helps us think through our fears about deprivation and loss in the context of our karis relationship with God. Here is Nancy's paraphrase of **Matthew 6:31–34**.

³¹Therefore, do not worry saying, "What will we eat?" or, "What will we drink?" or, "What will we put around our bodies?" ³²Why would you think that way? The people of this world, who are not in relationship with their Creator, desperately pursue all of these things, but you are the children of God! Our Father of the heavens understands that you need every one of these things. ³³Your business is first of all to pursue like a hunter the kingdom of God and orient your life to His way of doing things. That pursuit alone will yield great benefits, and then God, as your Lord and ally, is able to provide all things for you. ³⁴Therefore, do not worry about how you will meet your needs for tomorrow. Think of it this way. There is no point in worrying about tomorrow when you only have the power to make oriented choices today. This is a limitation. Tomorrow has its own worries. Mindfully deal with the misorientation of each day as it comes.

Take a deep breath.

In this passage, Jesus is trying to persuade you to give up your greed. He shows you how to arrange your priorities so that you can get what your True Self really wants. As a Christian and a child of God, what is your first priority? Are you seeking *first* His kingdom and His righteous way of doing things? Get into the business of orienting to God as your Lord and become His trustworthy servant and friend. The same energy that you spend on worrying or blaming can be applied to your training in mindful orientation. Orientation is cooperating with your Creator and offering your True Self to Him as a weapon of righteousness. If you are committed to that process, you can trust Him to supply everything else. As you consider your priorities, you might ask the Lord, *"Will this priority help You do what You want to do, and will it help orient me?" (Repeat)*

Our prayer might go something like this:

Father of the heavens, I want to make Your kingdom real in my life. Show me how. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume a meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider establishing a priority for your life. (Repeat) (Pause)*

The FAITH Process

Feelings

As you *consider establishing a priority for your life*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. You can learn to recognize and honor your feelings without allowing them to master you. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Gently hold this consideration of a priority in your awareness. You might notice a compulsion to push it away, despise it, or dismiss it. Observe whatever tension you may be feeling. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice how it reacts when you *consider establishing a priority for your life*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* You might say to yourself, "Oh, this is what hopelessness feels like in my body." You might feel liberation or permission. You might feel nothing at all. Breathe as you gently observe how your body responds to this priority. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider establishing a priority for your life*. What might Jesus say? Just observe. *(Pause)* What do you believe when you consider this priority? Why is this priority important to you? *(Pause)* Observe whatever you are experiencing as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

God created us to have feelings about all kinds of experiences and priorities. For thousands of years, human beings have felt like you feel when they have considered an area of specific priority. *(Pause)* When a feeling signals you through the body, you can focus on your body and your breath rather than reacting and getting caught up in stories. Breathe, and with a long exhaling breath invite your body to approach the possibility of this priority. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

(Optional) Continue to breathe while I test for further integration.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?”)

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for drawing us together for training and healing. Hold us in the power of new beginnings as You guide us to the truth about our needs. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we cooperate with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with You and Your kingdom, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

*Registration is open for the next NHG book study. Consider setting aside some time to return the gift of facilitating the discussion on one of the chapters.

(*Except when preparing for the Jubilee Year)

¹ *O Love that Will not Let Me Go* by George Matheson (1842–1906), www.youtube.com/watch?v=sxcnEBn1nA0, www.youtube.com/watch?v=cejtlUBokdo&list=RDcejtlUBokdo&start_radio=1.

² Prov. 22:13

³ Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (New York: Norton, 1991).